What Holds Society Together in the Age of AI?

On Human Freedom, Social Relationships and Collective Responsibility

What Zygmunt Bauman Can Teach Us About the Age of Artificial Intelligence

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A future he did not live to see

When sociologist and philosopher Zygmunt Bauman published Liquid Modernity in 2000, the internet was beginning to transform how people communicated, businesses operated and societies organised themselves. Globalisation was accelerating, established economic relationships were changing, and traditional institutions were losing some of their historical stability. Artificial intelligence, meanwhile, remained largely outside public awareness.

Bauman recognised a transformation that extended far beyond technology. He observed that the structures through which people had traditionally organised their lives were becoming increasingly fluid. Employment relationships, communities, social identities and institutions were losing their permanence. Individuals were gaining greater freedom to shape their own lives, but they were also becoming increasingly responsible for managing the uncertainties accompanying that freedom.

He called this condition liquid modernity (Bauman, 2000).

In the more stable structures of earlier modernity, organisations and institutions provided frameworks within which people could develop expectations about their future. Employment often implied a lasting relationship between employer and employee. Professional identities were closely connected to established occupations. Communities provided belonging, while public institutions offered mechanisms for managing risks and distributing responsibilities.

These arrangements were never equally beneficial to everyone. They could restrict individual freedom, reinforce hierarchies and exclude those who did not fit established expectations. Nevertheless, they offered a degree of continuity that helped people navigate the uncertainties of life.

Bauman argued that this continuity was increasingly disappearing. Companies could relocate, restructure or dissolve established relationships in pursuit of economic opportunities. Employees were expected to remain flexible and continuously adapt their capabilities. Individuals were encouraged to construct their own identities and assume responsibility for their personal success or failure.

His concern was not that society was changing. Change had always been part of modernity. His deeper concern was that the institutions and relationships through which people collectively managed uncertainty were weakening, while the responsibility for dealing with that uncertainty increasingly shifted towards individuals (Bauman, 2001b).

More than twenty-five years later, the rapid development of artificial intelligence invites us to revisit his thinking.

Bauman died in 2017, before contemporary generative AI became widely accessible. We cannot know how he would have interpreted these developments. Yet the tensions he identified provide a remarkably relevant perspective on the societal consequences of a world in which intelligence itself is becoming increasingly accessible, scalable and distributed.

The question is not simply what AI will make possible. It is what happens to society when the capabilities on which we depend become more fluid than the institutions and relationships through which we have traditionally organised them.

When intelligence becomes liquid

One of the most significant characteristics of contemporary AI is its ability to make capabilities previously associated with human expertise accessible through digital systems.

Knowledge, analysis, communication, creativity and elements of decision-making are becoming less dependent on established organisational structures or the direct availability of particular individuals.

A small business can access analytical capabilities that previously required specialist departments. Professionals can use intelligent systems to explore complex problems and develop alternative solutions. Students can obtain personalised explanations and feedback. Healthcare professionals can receive support in interpreting information and identifying possible courses of action.

These developments create opportunities to broaden access to knowledge and expertise. Capabilities that were once scarce, expensive or geographically concentrated can become available to a much wider population.

Yet the same developments may introduce another dimension to the fluidity Bauman described.

When expertise becomes accessible independently of established professional structures, the relationship between knowledge, work and organisational identity begins to change. When organisations can combine human and artificial capabilities in continuously changing configurations, established roles and responsibilities may become less permanent. And when individuals can rely on intelligent systems for activities previously requiring interaction with other people, the nature of some social relationships may also change.

None of these developments is inherently undesirable. Many established structures deserve reconsideration, and greater access to capabilities can improve people's lives.

The more fundamental issue is whether society can adapt its relationships and institutions at a pace that allows people to benefit from these changes without losing the foundations of security, belonging and mutual responsibility.

Bauman's concept of liquid modernity helps us recognise that technological flexibility and social progress are not necessarily the same thing.

A society can become more adaptable without becoming more inclusive. Organisations can become more productive without improving the security of their employees. Individuals can gain access to extraordinary capabilities while experiencing greater uncertainty about their future.

AI does not create these tensions. It enters a society in which they already exist and may significantly amplify them.

The paradox of individual empowerment

Individualisation occupies a central position in Bauman's analysis of modern society. As established structures become less prescriptive, individuals gain greater freedom to determine their own identities, relationships and careers. Yet the responsibility for managing the consequences of these choices increasingly rests with the individual.

What once appeared as a collective responsibility becomes a personal challenge.

Bauman (2001b) described how broader social problems are increasingly experienced as individual tasks. Economic insecurity becomes a question of personal employability. Social uncertainty becomes a challenge of individual adaptation. Success and failure are interpreted through personal choices, even when the underlying conditions are shaped by forces beyond individual control.

AI may intensify this development in contradictory ways.

On the one hand, it offers extraordinary possibilities for individual empowerment. People can develop capabilities beyond their formal education, access specialised knowledge and undertake activities that previously required substantial organisational support. AI can lower barriers to entrepreneurship, professional development and participation in economic and social life.

On the other hand, the widespread availability of these capabilities may raise expectations about what individuals should be able to accomplish independently.

If AI makes continuous learning easier, will employees increasingly be expected to manage their own professional transformation? If intelligent tools allow individuals to perform a wider range of tasks, will organisations become less willing to invest in long-term employment relationships? And if everyone has access to powerful digital assistance, will society become less tolerant of those who struggle to keep pace?

These are possibilities rather than inevitable consequences. Their significance depends on how organisations and institutions respond.

Nevertheless, they expose a fundamental paradox.

The more technology empowers individuals, the more responsibility society may place on those same individuals to manage an increasingly uncertain world.

Greater individual capability does not automatically create greater individual security.

This distinction becomes particularly important when considering the distribution of AI's economic benefits. Productivity improvements may create substantial value, but that value does not necessarily flow towards the people whose work is transformed or whose responsibilities increase.

Bauman's analysis encourages us to examine not only how AI changes what individuals can accomplish, but also how it changes the balance between individual freedom and collective responsibility.

Connected, but not necessarily together

Bauman's reflections on community offer another important perspective.

In Community: Seeking Safety in an Insecure World, he explored the tension between the desire for belonging and the desire for individual freedom (Bauman, 2001a). Communities can provide security, identity and mutual support, but they also require commitment and impose obligations.

In a liquid society, relationships increasingly become subject to individual choice. Connections can be established, maintained or abandoned according to changing preferences and circumstances.

Bauman returned to this theme in a 2016 interview with El País, where he discussed the distinction between digital networks and genuine communities. He argued that networks offer individuals considerable control over their connections, while communities involve a different kind of belonging and commitment (de Querol, 2016).

His concern was not simply that people were spending too much time online. It was that digital connectivity might create the appearance of community without necessarily developing the social capabilities and reciprocal responsibilities on which meaningful relationships depend.

AI introduces a new dimension to this concern.

Intelligent systems are increasingly capable of engaging in natural conversations, offering personalised guidance and responding to emotional expressions. They may provide valuable support to people experiencing isolation, help individuals overcome communication barriers and make assistance more accessible.

These possibilities deserve serious consideration, particularly in societies where loneliness and unequal access to services are significant concerns.

Yet interaction and relationship are not identical.

An AI system may reproduce many characteristics of human communication without participating in the reciprocal obligations that define human relationships. It can respond to questions and offer advice, but it does not share responsibility for the consequences in the same way as a colleague, friend, teacher or fellow citizen.

This distinction matters when institutions begin replacing human interactions with digital services.

Consider education. AI can provide personalised explanations, immediate feedback and access to learning resources that would otherwise be unavailable. These capabilities may significantly improve educational opportunities.

But education is also a social process. Students develop judgement through dialogue, learn to collaborate with others and encounter perspectives that challenge their assumptions. Teachers do more than transfer knowledge. They help students develop confidence, responsibility and a sense of belonging within a learning community.

A similar tension exists in healthcare, public administration and professional services. Efficient digital interactions can improve accessibility and reduce unnecessary administrative burdens. Yet the quality of these services also depends on trust, understanding and human judgement.

The issue is therefore not whether AI can provide valuable assistance. It clearly can.

The deeper question is whether we will continue to recognise the value of human relationships when technological alternatives become increasingly convenient.

Bauman's work reminds us that being connected is not necessarily the same as belonging.

The changing balance between individual and collective capability

Much of the contemporary discussion about AI focuses on its contribution to individual and organisational performance. Employees can become more productive, businesses more competitive and individuals more capable of managing complex tasks.

These developments are important, but they represent only one dimension of AI's potential societal impact.

Many of the challenges facing modern societies cannot be resolved through individual capabilities alone.

Healthcare systems must coordinate expertise, resources and responsibilities across multiple institutions. Energy transitions require cooperation between governments, businesses and citizens. Education depends on the combined contributions of students, teachers, institutions and wider communities.

AI may strengthen individual capabilities within these systems, but their effectiveness ultimately depends on how those capabilities are connected.

This reveals an important distinction.

Individual capability concerns what people can accomplish independently. Collective capability concerns what people can accomplish together.

The two are related, but they are not interchangeable.

A society consisting of highly capable individuals is not necessarily a society capable of addressing complex collective challenges. Individual access to knowledge does not automatically produce shared understanding. Personal autonomy does not necessarily generate cooperation. Greater efficiency within separate organisations does not guarantee better outcomes across an entire system.

Indeed, when technological development primarily reinforces individual competitiveness, it may contribute to the fragmentation Bauman described.

At the same time, AI offers possibilities that extend beyond individual empowerment. Intelligent systems can help identify patterns across complex systems, make distributed knowledge more accessible and support coordination between people and institutions.

Whether these possibilities translate into greater collective capability remains an open question.

The distinction is nevertheless significant because it changes how we evaluate technological progress.

If AI enables individuals to accomplish more, we may consider that an important achievement. But if the same development weakens shared institutions or increases the burden of uncertainty carried by individuals, its broader societal consequences become more ambiguous.

A more intelligent society is not necessarily a society that is better at acting together.

This may be one of the most important questions emerging from the encounter between Bauman's thinking and contemporary AI.

The institutions we still depend on

Bauman's analysis also challenges the assumption that technological progress will naturally reduce our dependence on established institutions.

As intelligent systems become more capable, activities traditionally organised through schools, businesses, healthcare organisations and public institutions may increasingly be performed through digital platforms.

This creates opportunities to reconsider institutional arrangements that have become unnecessarily complex, expensive or inflexible.

Yet institutions perform functions that extend beyond the efficient delivery of services.

They establish expectations, distribute responsibilities, protect shared interests and provide continuity. They create frameworks within which people can rely on commitments that extend beyond individual transactions.

These functions become particularly important when economic and technological conditions are changing rapidly.

A healthcare system is not merely a collection of medical services. It also represents a set of social commitments concerning access, responsibility and care. An educational institution does more than provide information. It contributes to the development of citizens and the transmission of knowledge, values and professional standards.

Similarly, organisations are more than temporary combinations of productive resources. They can provide opportunities for professional development, shared identity and long-term cooperation.

The increasing availability of AI capabilities does not eliminate these functions. It may, however, change how they are organised and who is responsible for maintaining them.

There is an additional tension.

While AI may reduce individuals' dependence on particular organisations or professional intermediaries, it may simultaneously create new dependencies on digital infrastructures, data ecosystems and technology providers.

Greater freedom at one level can therefore coexist with greater dependency at another.

This resembles a broader theme in Bauman's work: the unequal distribution of freedom and uncertainty. Those who control resources and mobility may benefit from increasing flexibility, while others experience its consequences as insecurity.

In the AI era, the distribution of technological capabilities and the control of essential infrastructures may become increasingly important dimensions of this inequality.

The question is not whether traditional institutions should remain unchanged. Many will need to evolve.

It is whether the transformation of institutions will preserve the social responsibilities that make them valuable.

Progress without certainty

Bauman's work was not simply a nostalgic defence of the past. His analysis recognised the limitations of earlier forms of modernity and the tensions between security and freedom.

In liquid modernity, individuals may gain opportunities that were previously unavailable, but they also lose some of the structures that helped them navigate uncertainty.

AI brings this tension into sharper focus.

It can make knowledge more accessible while challenging established professional identities. It can increase organisational flexibility while creating uncertainty about employment relationships. It can expand opportunities for individual expression while potentially changing the nature of human interaction.

It can strengthen our ability to understand complex systems, yet it may also increase our dependence on technological infrastructures that few individuals fully understand or control.

These developments resist simple classifications of progress or decline.

Their consequences are neither uniform nor predetermined. They depend on economic incentives, institutional arrangements, political decisions, cultural expectations and the ways people choose to use intelligent technologies.

This is precisely why Bauman's perspective remains valuable.

He encourages us to look beyond the immediate benefits of greater flexibility and ask what happens to the social relationships and responsibilities that provide continuity in people's lives.

Technological progress may expand the range of choices available to individuals, but it does not remove the need to make collective choices about the society in which those individuals live.

The question of AI's societal value therefore cannot be answered solely by measuring productivity, economic growth or the performance of intelligent systems.

It also requires us to consider what happens to human agency, social trust, shared responsibility and the capacity of institutions to serve collective interests.

The questions Bauman leaves us

Zygmunt Bauman did not live to see the emergence of contemporary generative AI. It would be misleading to present his work as a prediction of the technological developments we are now experiencing.

Yet his analysis of liquid modernity provides a powerful lens through which to examine their possible societal consequences.

He showed how increasing freedom can coexist with increasing insecurity, how greater connectivity can fail to produce genuine community, and how individualisation can shift responsibility for collective problems towards individuals.

AI may intensify these tensions. It may also create possibilities that were not available when Bauman developed his ideas.

The significance of these possibilities lies not only in what intelligent systems can accomplish, but also in how their capabilities affect the relationships between individuals, organisations and society.

Will greater access to intelligence strengthen individual autonomy while preserving the social foundations on which that autonomy depends?

Will increasingly flexible organisations continue to provide meaningful opportunities for belonging, development and shared responsibility?

Will intelligent technologies strengthen our ability to cooperate, or will they primarily make it easier for individuals and institutions to operate independently?

And as intelligence becomes more widely distributed, who will carry responsibility for the consequences of the decisions it helps us make?

These questions cannot be resolved by technology alone. Nor can they be answered by returning to the institutional arrangements of the past.

They require us to reconsider the relationship between individual capability and collective responsibility in a society where intelligence is no longer exclusively human.

Bauman helped us understand why modern society was becoming increasingly liquid. AI may make that society more fluid still.

The defining question is whether the growing intelligence available to individuals and organisations will also strengthen our capacity to live, decide and act together.

Perhaps that is the most important challenge of the AI era. Not simply to create more intelligent machines, but to understand what it means to become a more intelligent society.

References

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